Parshas Matos–Masei

What Are We Building Through Our Discomfort?

Nedarim · The Three Weeks · 42 Journeys · Yirmiyahu

I. Discomfort With a Purpose

This Shabbos arrives already within the Three Weeks, as we approach the Nine Days. We always have to remember the halachos and hanhagos of this time, reducing simcha and limiting certain activities. But reducing simcha does not mean destroying ourselves emotionally. It does not mean we are supposed to collapse into despair.

As my Rebbe, Rav Gerzi of Pilzno, mentions and reiterates so often: it is okay to be uncomfortable. It is okay to experience discomfort as an individual. There are moments in life when discomfort itself has value. It slows us down, interrupts our routines, and forces us to confront questions we would otherwise avoid. The Three Weeks are meant to make us uncomfortable because we are not living in our complete reality. Even sitting here in Beit Shemesh, even with Shabbos being prepared, we are still in galus. The Shechinah is in exile. The world is not yet as it is supposed to be. The question the parsha is going to push us toward is not whether we feel that discomfort, but what we are doing with it.

II. The Responsibility of a Word

Parshas Matos opens in a striking way. Moshe Rabbeinu gathers the roshei hamatos, the leaders of the tribes, and teaches them specifically the halachos of nedarim. This is worth pausing on. The normal process of Torah transmission flowed from Hashem to Moshe, from Moshe to Aharon, from Aharon to his sons, then to the elders, and eventually to the entire nation. That organized chain had already been established. Yet here the Torah specifies that these particular halachos go first to the leadership.

Why?

Because the message of nedarim is specifically a message about leadership. A neder is not simply a promise to do a mitzvah we are already obligated to do. We have a chiyuv for that regardless. A neder creates a new restriction upon something otherwise permitted, or it represents a commitment to go beyond what would ordinarily be expected. It is a person

saying with their words: I am taking this on. And the Torah treats those words with tremendous seriousness.

כְּכָל הַיֹּצֵא מִפִּיו יַעֲשֶׂה

"Whatever comes from his mouth, he shall do."
— Bamidbar 30:3

Leadership begins with the integrity of one's word. A Torah leader cannot be guided only by what is popular, comfortable, or politically convenient. Democratic systems tend to follow the popular vote. Torah leadership is supposed to identify the right person for the responsibility, someone who understands what the job truly requires and will make sure it is done properly. Doing mitzvos is not always easy. It is okay to be uncomfortable. Leadership is supposed to instill those values and hold the line when others are tempted to let go. Moshe Rabbeinu teaching the leaders about nedarim is Moshe teaching them what they are actually for.

And this applies not only to public leaders. Every Jew leads within some sphere. We lead our homes, influence our children, shape our communities. Our national relationship with Hashem also began with a declaration: na'aseh v'nishma, we will do and we will listen. That was not merely an emotional moment at Har Sinai. It was a covenantal commitment. Matos asks whether we still live as people whose words carry that weight.

III. What Comes First

Later in Matos, the tribes of Reuven and Gad approach Moshe with a request to settle on the eastern side of the Yarden. Their land is good for their abundant livestock, and they propose their plan: they will build enclosures for their animals and cities for their children and wives.

Moshe reverses the order when he responds. First, build cities for your children. Then, build enclosures for your animals. The adjustment is subtle and easy to miss, but the Torah is making a point about priorities. A person's values are revealed by what they mention first. Possessions, livelihood, and security all matter. But family comes before property. The mission of entering Eretz Yisrael required clarity about what was being built, not only where to build it.

IV. Every Journey Has a Purpose

Masei then records the forty-two journeys of Bnei Yisrael through the Midbar, listing every stop from the departure from Mitzrayim until they arrived at the plains of Moav, ready to cross into the Land. On the surface it reads like a travel itinerary. But the Baal Shem Tov teaches that these forty-two journeys correspond to the stages of every person's life.

Some encampments were extraordinarily brief. They set up camp and almost immediately had to move again. Life can change that quickly. A person gets married, has children, changes direction entirely, or receives unexpected news. Within a moment, the entire world looks different. Other encampments lasted for years. There are stages of life where a person remains in one place for a long time, sometimes comfortable, sometimes stagnant, sometimes genuinely painful.

But every stop is in the Torah because every stop had a purpose. Rebbe Nachman teaches extensively about descending into difficult places and discovering that there is still avodah to be done there. Sometimes a person cannot simply lift themselves out of a low place by smiling or forcing happiness. There may be nitzotzei kedushah, sparks of holiness, that can only be elevated from that particular low place by that particular person in that particular moment. The question is not only how quickly we can escape the discomfort. The question is what we are meant to accomplish while we are here.

V. We Were Brought Here for a Reason

The haftorah for this week carries a powerful tochachah from Yirmiyahu, and it is not coincidental that it falls during the Three Weeks. Yirmiyahu speaks on behalf of Hashem to remind Klal Yisrael of everything that was given to them and what was done with it. Hashem took us out of Mitzrayim not as a random act of mercy, but because He wanted us to be His nation. He gave us Eretz Yisrael not merely as a place to live, but as a place in which to fulfill a mission.

The haftorah describes what happened next:

כִּי מֵעוֹלָם שָׁבַרְתִּי עֻלֵּךְ נִתַּקְתִּי מוֹסְרוֹתַיִךְ וַתֹּאמְרִי לֹא אֶעֱבֹד

"From long ago I broke your yoke and tore away your bonds, and you said: I will not serve."

— Yirmiyahu 2:20

Hashem released us from the bondage of Mitzrayim. We declared that we would serve Him rather than the false powers of the world. And then the pasuk continues by describing the nation turning again toward idolatry. We made a commitment and then forgot it.

This connects directly to the opening of Matos. Matos teaches the seriousness of a neder, of a word given and a commitment made. Yirmiyahu confronts us with the broken commitments of Jewish history. The thread runs from Har Sinai through every generation. We said na'aseh v'nishma. We committed to something. The question the haftorah puts back to us is whether we are still living that commitment, or whether we have quietly forgotten why we were taken out of Mitzrayim to begin with.

VI. What Are We Building?

Chazal teach that in every generation in which the Beis HaMikdash is not rebuilt, it is considered as though that generation destroyed it. This teaching is not meant to crush us with guilt. It is meant to give us responsibility. If the destruction were only an ancient tragedy, we could mourn it and move on. But if its continued absence reflects something still lacking in us, then our actions today matter.

There are children's songs that describe each mitzvah as adding another brick to the Beis HaMikdash HaShlishi. My children love those songs, and the image is simple but it contains real truth. Redemption is built through individual acts of faithfulness. A mitzvah performed properly adds something to the world. A commitment honored adds something. A priority corrected adds something. A relationship repaired adds something.

During the Three Weeks we become uncomfortable. We stop listening to music. We avoid celebrations. As we enter the Nine Days, additional restrictions come. But discomfort is not the goal. Discomfort is the setting in which the real avodah can take place. If we refrain from music but do not become more reflective, what have we built? If we mourn the Beis HaMikdash but continue to damage relationships and treat our commitments casually, what has changed? The question is not only what are we giving up. The question is what are we building.

And this also means not making dramatic nedarim that we cannot fulfill. The Torah itself warns us not to create binding commitments carelessly. If we take on a neder and fail to uphold it, we may have created an aveirah rather than a tikkun. Real growth is not measured by the size of a promise. It is measured by the faithfulness with which we live

it. One small commitment that is genuinely kept may accomplish more than a grand declaration that disappears after a few days.

VII. From Mourning to Moed

Tisha B'Av is called a moed. For now, it is a moed expressed through mourning. But the neviim teach that these days are destined to become days of actual joy and celebration. The goal is not to remain permanently in the low place. The goal is to accomplish the avodah that belongs there and then emerge transformed.

The forty-two journeys did not end in the wilderness. They moved toward Eretz Yisrael. The exile is also a journey. The Three Weeks are also a stage within that journey. Every stop exists for a reason, and this one is no different. May we use these days to take our words seriously, reorder our priorities, repair what needs repairing, and build another brick in the Beis HaMikdash. May Rosh Chodesh Av no longer introduce deeper restrictions, but open new possibilities. And may Tisha B'Av this year become the moed of joy it is destined to be.

חזק ואחזק

Good Shabbos

Reflection Questions

> - *What discomfort am I currently sitting in, and what might the avodah be that belongs specifically to that low place? Am I trying to escape it too quickly?*
> - *Are there commitments, to Hashem, to my family, or to my community, that I made and have quietly let slip? What would it mean to take one of them seriously again this week?*
> - *Like Reuven and Gad, what do I mention first when describing my plans? Does that order reflect what I actually value?*
> - *What is one small, sustainable commitment I can take on during the Three Weeks that I am actually capable of keeping, rather than a dramatic promise that may not last?*
> - *What brick am I adding to the Beis HaMikdash today? Can I name something specific I am doing that is moving the world, even slightly, toward geulah?*
> - *Tisha B'Av is called a moed. What would need to change in my life, or in the world, for that mourning to genuinely transform into celebration? What is my part in that transformation?*